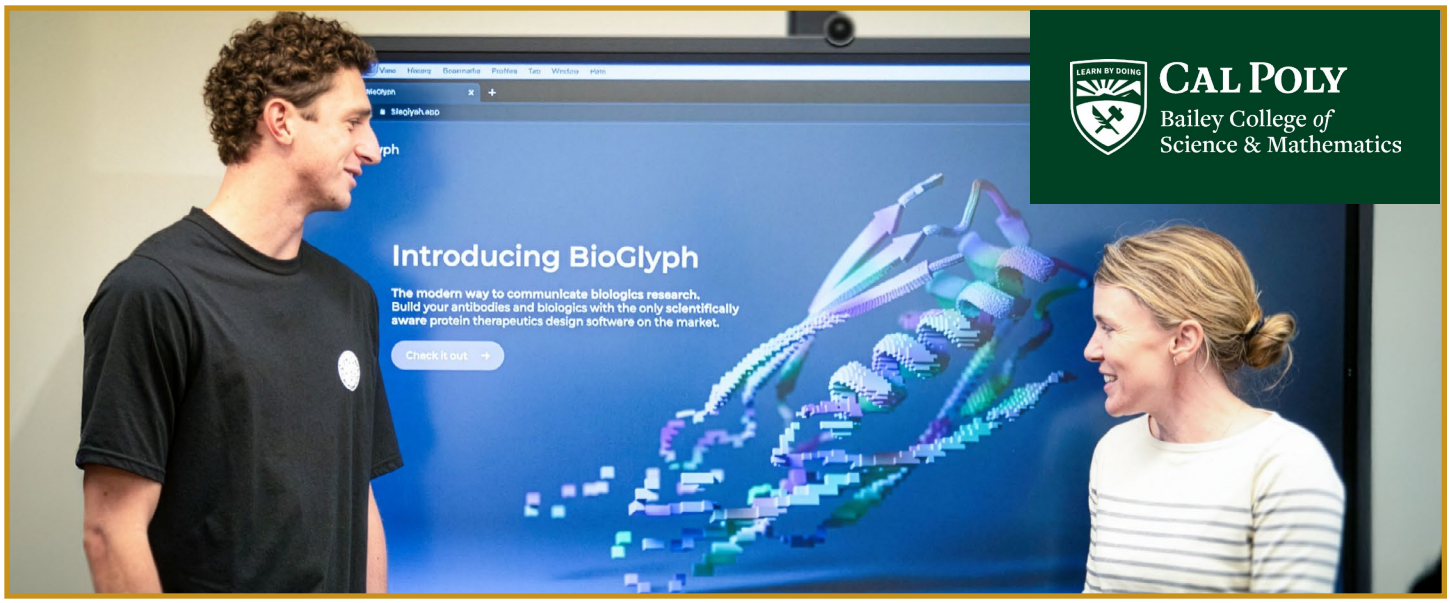

CAL POLY
Bailey College *of* Science & Mathematics

INNOVATION, EMBEDDED

Entrepreneurship at Cal Poly works best when it lives inside the colleges, not beside them. The Center for Innovation and Entrepreneurship (CIE) has built a nationally recognized program rooted in Learn by Doing, and its next chapter depends on faculty leaders embedded across all six colleges, connecting the center to the disciplines where ideas actually take shape.

A PERMANENT BRIDGE BETWEEN THE CIE AND THE DISCIPLINES

The CIE today draws students naturally from business and engineering. But the problems facing California, in health, energy, climate, materials, and water, require chemistry, physics, mathematics, and the deep technical expertise that lives in the Bailey College of Science and Mathematics. To embed entrepreneurship into a Cal Poly education, the center needs faculty partners in every college: people who advise students, sustain projects across the natural turnover of a campus, and open doors to laboratories and specialized knowledge.

The vision is to have one Endowed Faculty Innovation Lead in each of Cal Poly's six colleges, working together as a council, bringing CIE programs into academic units and bringing disciplinary expertise back to the center.

BAILEY COLLEGE IS READY

The Bailey College already has a Faculty Innovation Lead. Dr. Erik Sapper, faculty in the Chemistry and Biochemistry Department, has served in this role for four years through private funding, building the Bailey College Innovation Initiative into a proven program. Under his leadership, students have launched projects ranging from algae-based recovery supplements to precision diagnostics for urinary tract infections. Fellows have been mentored by alumni and industry leaders, participated in summer and academic Innovation Fellowship Programs that include faculty mentors, and gathered with mentors, faculty, and peers at our annual Bailey Innovation Gathering.

Innovation in science takes longer and requires laboratory infrastructure, deeper faculty mentorship, and patience for ideas that move from discovery to application over years, not months. Dr. Sapper's role has made that work possible.

WHAT AN ENDOWMENT MAKES POSSIBLE

An endowment changes the nature of the role. It signals that innovation is not a pilot or an initiative, but a permanent fixture of a Cal Poly education. It anchors the Bailey College to the CIE in a partnership that benefits both. And it allows the Faculty Innovation Lead position to rotate every three to five years, elevating an entire generation of faculty across the college and steadily building the culture of entrepreneurship the university is reaching toward.

The funding provides one-third release time for the faculty member, the most precious resource in academic life: time to focus, advise, and build. As an endowed appointment, it carries the prestige that signals to the entire university that this work matters.

THE ROLE

- **ADVISE** a cohort of student innovators each year, guiding individual projects and convening the cohort for collective feedback and cross-pollination.
- **CONNECT** university-wide projects to science and mathematics expertise. When a business student's app needs a chemist, or an engineering team needs a mathematician, the bridge is already built.
- **SERVE** on a CIE council of Faculty Innovation Leads from across all six colleges, shaping CIE programs and bringing them into the academic units.
- **LEAD** a culture of innovation within the Bailey College, supporting both students and the faculty who advise them.
- **CONTINUE** to grow the Bailey College Innovation Program, including our funded Student Innovation Fellows program.

THE OPPORTUNITY

A gift of **$1,000,000** establishes the Endowed Bailey Faculty Innovation Lead in perpetuity, generating approximately **$40,000** per year to support the appointment. Our goal is to secure the pathway to this endowment during calendar year 2026.

Endowed gifts at Cal Poly can be made through cash, appreciated securities, real estate, or donor-advised funds. Learn more at **plannedgiving.calpoly.edu/endowed-gifts.**

BAILEY COLLEGE OF SCIENCE AND MATHEMATICS | CENTER FOR INNOVATION AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP
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